



attack, and the Indian midfield of Ashique Kuruniyan, Anirudh Thapa, Apuia and Liston Colaco, made Mohun Bagan's attacks quite effective.

Before things could go out of control, Mohun Bagan earned a penalty in the 50th minute thanks to Jamshedpur defender Pronay Halder handling the ball while trying to clear Cummings' corner. The Australian forward converted the spot-kick and levelled the aggregate at 2-2.

Back in the game, Mohun Bagan redoubled its effort but failed to convert its chances until Apuia discovered his golden touch in added time (90+4 minute) to get the ball past Gomes and prevent the match from trickling into extra time.

Amitabha Das Sharma

Chhetri to the rescue

On April 6, the Jawaharlal Nehru Stadium in Fatorda and its vicinity was painted orange and blue.

FC Goa clashed with Bengaluru FC in the second leg of their ISL

semifinal. With the home team coming into the match trailing 0-2 from the first leg, the onus was on Manolo Marquez's men to turn the tide.

Before the second leg, Marquez appealed to the FC Goa faithful to turn up in numbers — and the fans did not disappoint. Braving the harsh Goan heat, fans started arriving at the ground almost three hours before kick-off.

As the Bengaluru fans began to roll in, the inevitable happened, as chant wars broke out between the two fanbases.

The police remained vigilant to ensure that the banter did not take an ugly turn. However, both sets of fans behaved and kept the spirit of football alive as the 'Forca Goa' and 'Namma Bengaluru' chants reverberated across Padre Pedru Ferrao Road.

The Diary, whose hotel was located very near the stadium, heard K'naan's iconic song *Wavin' Flag* being played on speakers, prompting him to get ready even

Last laugh: Veteran Sunil Chhetri rescued Bengaluru with a late strike to take it to the final. *ISL*

faster and join the thick of the action to gauge the mood of the fans.

"That 2-0 loss was just a decoy to lure Bengaluru into our home. Today, FC Goa will show their real strength, and we will beat them 5-3," said Oscar, an FC Goa fan since 2016.

Countering him, Smarth, a Bengaluru fan and part of the famous 'West Block Blues', said, "You really think Goa can get back into the match? We're already planning to book tickets for the final. We're already through."

In the end, it was the fans in blue who had the last laugh. While Goa pulled back two goals to level the tie, Sunil Chhetri had the final say by scoring in the 90+2 minute to send Bengaluru to the final, where it will face Mohun Bagan Super Giant on April 12.

Aneesh Dey